

Session 10: Melchizedek the Royal Priest

Key Takeaways

- This narrative offers us the first picture of Avram's transformation as he more faithfully reflects God's image.
- The kings of Salem and Sodom stand in stark contrast to one another. The king of Salem comes with feast and blessing, whereas the king of Sodom comes to take.
- Biblical authors hold up Melchizedek as an ideal, untainted royal priest.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 14:17-24

a 17 And **the king of Sodom** **went out to meet him**,
b after he returned from **striking** Kedorlaomer, and the kings with him,
a' into the valley of the plain [this is the valley of the king].

18 Now (just then), **Melchizedek, king of Shalem**, **brought out bread and wine**.
A Now, he was the **priest** of **El-Most High**
19 And he **blessed** him, and he said:
May Avram be **blessed** by **El-Most High**,
B the **possessor of skies and land**.
20 And may **El-Most High** be **blessed**,
who has delivered your adversaries into your hand.
A **And he gave to him** (נתן) **a tenth** (עשר) **of everything**.

21 And **the king of Sodom** **said to Avram**,
A **"Give to me** (נתן) **the people**,
and the possessions, **take** (לקח) **for yourself**."

22 And **Avram said to the king of Sodom**,
"I lift up my hand to Yahweh, **El-Most High**,
possessor of skies and land:
B 23 Not from a strap or sole of a sandal
will I **take** (לקח) from all that is yours,
so that you can't say,

'I made Avram **wealthy** (עשר)!'!

a 24 Only what the **young men** have eaten,

A b and **the portion** (חלק) of the men who went with me,

a' **Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre,**

b' they can **take** (לקח) their **portion** (חלק)."

Genesis 14:1-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

A Tale of Two Kings

This story needs to be understood from multiple perspectives, like a concentric circle with each layer moving outward and getting larger: Genesis 14:17-24 within Genesis 14:1-24, within 11:27-14:24, within 11:27-25:18, within Genesis as a whole, within the Torah as a whole, and in relationship to the Prophets and Writings.

With Melchizedek, we come to the 10th king in the story! In contrast to the king of Sodom, whose name is "Evil" (ברע), we now have the "King of Righteousness" (מלכי־צדק)! The contrast in their names symbolizes their characters and what they want for or from Avram.

Bera King of Sodom

- Sodom / Evil
- He demands that Avram give (נתן) him the war captives, but Avram can take (לקח) the plunder.
- He wants to have Avram in his debt by making him wealthy (עשר).

Mekhizedeq King-Priest of Salem

- Salem (= Jerusalem) / Righteousness
- He offers food and blessing to Avram and demands nothing in return.
- He gives generously to Avram, so Avram happily gives (נתן) one-tenth (מעשר) as a gift in return.

Bera and Melchizedek represent two ways that the rulers of nations relate to God's chosen one, who was selected to be the conduit of God's blessing to the nations. Recall God's promise to Avram in Genesis 12:3.

Genesis 12:3 Instructor's Translation

Those who bless you will be blessed,
those who treat you as insignificant will be cursed
and through you, all the families of the land will find blessing.

"It is perfectly natural that a returning hero, whose victory has also benefited the entire region, should be officially greeted by a distinguished personage. But the intrusive nature of the report here, interrupting the smooth sequence of verses 17 and 21, is obvious, and was noted by Rashi, Abravanel, and Hizkuni. Its position, which is original and not a later insertion, heightens the tension produced by the sudden appearance of the king of Sodom, whose very name is redolent of evil. It also transforms into a spiritual experience what was up to now a secular incident. Victory in war is not attributed to Abram's skill and valor but to the will of God, who is the ultimate arbiter of human destiny. It is inconceivable that the biblical

Narrator would not have introduced such a note into the story. The artfulness with which the Melchizedek episode is integrated into the narrative is proven by the priest-king's mention of Abram's victory and by reference to the 'Valley of the King' (v. 17), which smooths the way for the appearance of the 'king of Salem,' the first element of whose name—Melchizedek—also means 'king.' There is a subtle contrast in the uses of the verb *y-ts-*, 'to go out.' The king of Sodom 'came out' empty-handed to meet his benefactor, and the first word he uttered was 'give!' The king of Salem 'brought out' bread and wine and offered a blessing, even though he may have come to collect his tithe. The name of Melchizedek's city—Salem (Heb. *shalem*)—is suggestive of shalom, the peace that Abram's intervention brought to the region. Finally, the extraordinary title of God used by Abram in his colloquy with the king of Sodom is the name just used twice by Melchizedek."

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [*The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 109.

A Royal Priest Who Blesses the Blessed One

Melchizedek is the first explicit "royal priest" in the book of Genesis. Adam and Eve are implicitly royal priests, but Melchizedek is clearly a royal priest, and not from the line of Seth, Noah, or Shem (or at least, not in the text).

He rules Salem (lit. *shalem* / שָׁלֵם), which later in the Hebrew Bible is identified as JeruSALEM (see [Ps. 76:1-2](#), where "God's tent is in Salem, his dwelling is in Zion"). It will later be called "Jebus" when it is in the possession of the Canaanites ([Josh. 18:28](#); [Judg. 19:10-11](#); [2 Sam. 5:6-7](#)).

Melchizedek pronounces a blessing on Avraham in the name of El-Elyon, the creator/possessor of skies and land. This divine title, and Avraham's statement in [14:22](#) that El-Elyon is Yahweh, links Melchizedek's God to "Yahweh *Elohim*" of [Genesis 1-2](#). He is a genuine priest of the God of Israel, but before Israel ever existed, and before Yahweh was known by that name (see [Exod. 3:12-15](#)). This connects him to the line of genuine worship that stems back to Seth in [Genesis 4:26](#).

Melchizedek's blessing on Avram links back to God's promise in [Genesis 12:1-3](#). Thus, we can expect that Melchizedek and the city he rules will experience God's blessing some time in the future.

Genesis 14:19-20 NASB

¹⁹ He **blessed** him and said,
"Blessed be Abram of God Most High,
possessor of heaven and earth;
²⁰ And **blessed be God Most High**,
who has delivered your enemies into your hand."
And he gave him a tenth of all.

Genesis 12:2-3 NASB

² And I will make you a great nation,
and I will **bless** you,
and make your name great;
and so you shall be a **blessing**;
³ and **I will bless those who bless you**,

and the one who curses you I will curse.
And in you all the families of the earth will be **blessed**.

Notice how Melchizedek's blessing develops God's own blessing on Avram. God has promised seed and land, and now Melchizedek adds deliverance from enemies. God will bless Avram with abundant descendants and a promised land, and he will deliver Avram's descendants from their enemies.

God's Promise of Blessing

An important theme at work in Genesis 14 is the blessing of God upon Avram, and how the various characters in the story relate to Avram.

Genesis 14:13-14 NASB*

¹³ Then a fugitive came and told Abram the Hebrew. Now, he was living by the oaks of **Mamre the Amorite, brother of Eshcol and brother of Aner, and these were in a covenant with Abram.**

¹⁴ When Abram heard that his relative had been taken captive, he led out his trained men, born in his house, three hundred and eighteen, and went in pursuit as far as Dan.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

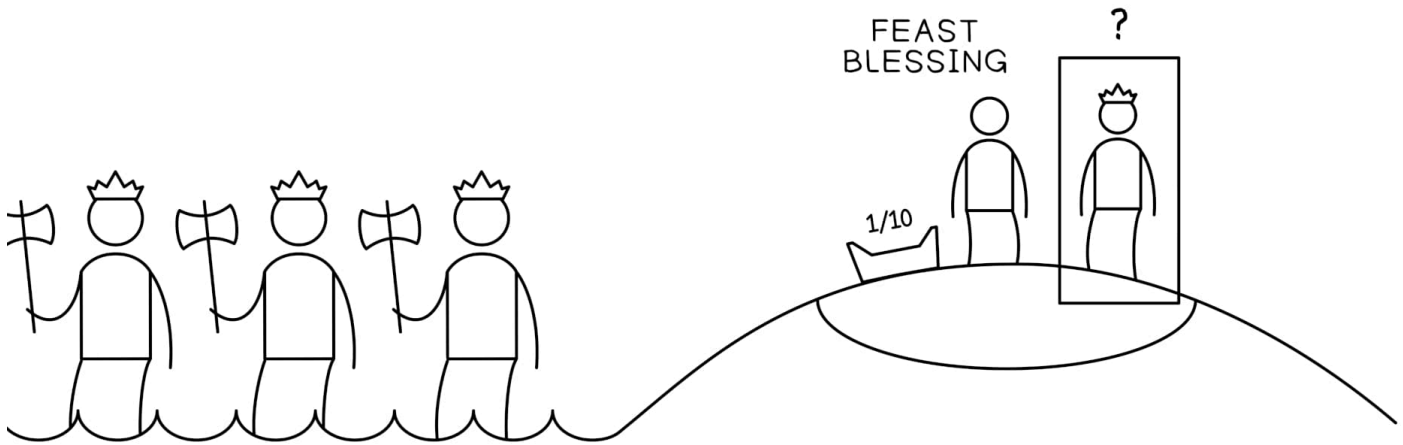
These Amorites who had made a covenant with Avram, God's chosen one, experienced the blessing of God's protection and also shared in the victory of Avram. In contrast, the gentile kings who oppose God's chosen one are defeated despite the odds in their favor. This contrast bears an important message: God's blessing upon Avram can be experienced by the nations if they relate peaceably with God's chosen one, like Mamre and his crew, or like Melchizedek.

Genesis 14 shows the outworking of God's promise in Genesis 12:2-3. Avram becomes a blessing to the nations as he fights against violent, pagan kings and rescues the innocent. And those who "cursed" him (by kidnapping his nephew) find themselves cursed.

Melchizedek blesses Avram, and so we expect God will bless Melchizedek in return. The payment of a tithe to Melchizedek shows that Avram honors him as a superior. The sudden introduction and disappearance of Melchizedek leaves a great impression on the reader.

The reader is unsurprised when, much later in the story, David is made king of Israel and establishes this same city as Israel's sacred capitol. David moves the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem and assumes the role of a royal priest just like Melchizedek! See 2 Samuel 5-8.

Avram and Melchizedek



Avram and Melchizedek. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How does Genesis 14:17-24 begin to demonstrate a transformation in Avram's character?